```
    array(1) {
      ["cat"]=>
      string(4) "jess"
    }
  }
  ["humans"]=>
  array(2) {
    [0]=>
    string(4) "anna"
    [1]=>
    string(4) "paul"
  }
}
```

`json_decode()` will return either an associative array or a structure composed of `stdClass` objects, depending on the second boolean argument: we've opted for an associative array here. JSON is widely used these days for sending structured data in a POST or PUT and is generally preferred because it is very easy to work with in browsers (which run JavaScript). You might also encounter XML in your travels, particularly in older corners of the internet. Let's rejig the example accordingly, using PHP's `SimpleXML` module, which should be installed by default…

```
// index.php
$requestBody = file_get_contents('php://input');
$xml = new SimpleXMLElement($requestBody);
var_dump($xml->children());
```

… and tweak our curl command by changing `Content-Type:` to `application/xml` and reformatting the request data as valid XML:

```
$ curl -X 'POST' -H 'Content-Type: application/xml' \
  -d '<?xml version="1.0" encoding="utf-8"?>
  <data>
  <animals>
    <cat><jess/></cat>
  </animals>
  <humans>
```